

EXECUTIVE RESEARCH REPORT

Architecting More Predictable Enterprise Value from Data, Technology and AI Investment

Research and Practical Guidance for Turning Transformation Investment into Measurable Business Value

82

EXECUTIVES
SURVEYED

52.4%

REPORTED HALF OR FEWER INITIATIVES FULLY
DELIVERED

9.2x

DEDICATED OWNERSHIP
ASSOCIATION

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Most data, digital, and now AI initiatives do not fail because the business case was wrong. They fail because the organization was never adjusted to deliver it.

A survey of 82 senior executives found that half or fewer of their organizations' data and digital initiatives fully delivered the commercial outcomes that justified them, and that technology is routinely selected before the business outcome is defined. Initiatives with dedicated ownership and resources were substantially more likely to fully deliver than those treated as an additional responsibility for the business-as-usual team. Not one respondent whose organization had none of five key operating conditions reported full delivery.

82

Senior executives surveyed

52.4%

Reported half or fewer initiatives fully delivered expected outcomes

65.9%

Technology selected before the business outcome

9.2x

Full-delivery rate with dedicated ownership vs. business as usual



WHERE ORGANIZATIONS FALL SHORT

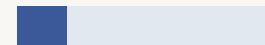
52.4%

Of surveyed executives, 43 of 82 reported that half or fewer data and digital initiatives fully delivered the expected commercial outcomes.

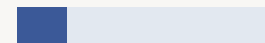
Technology selected before business outcome

**65.9%**

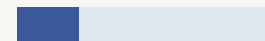
Readiness assessed before capital committed

**19.5%**

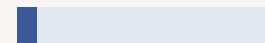
Method for measuring value defined in advance

**19.5%**

Dedicated ownership and resources

**23.8%**

Incentives redesigned to support the initiative

**7.3%**



WHY I STUDIED THIS PROBLEM

Earlier in my career, I was asked to help address complex technology initiatives that had defined objectives but lacked several conditions required for successful execution. Significant resources had been invested in engineering, development and product work, yet the initiatives were incomplete and the expected return had not materialized. Stakeholders were asking why the work was not finished and where the value was.

The existing presentations were polished and the high-level vision appeared logical. When I looked beneath the presentations, much of the rigorous work required to make the vision executable was missing. Process maps were incomplete. Dependencies were not fully understood. Business requirements lacked necessary detail. Manual workarounds and tribal knowledge shaped how the work was actually performed.

I met with the accountable stakeholders, reviewed the project documentation and financial objectives, assembled a cross-functional team spanning product management, architecture, engineering, business analysis and project management, and went to the front lines. We asked employees to show us how the work was performed, where their time went, what prevented them from accomplishing more, and which tasks or outcomes were not possible with the existing systems. Their knowledge revealed unnecessary workarounds, hidden dependencies and opportunities that were not visible in the executive-level materials.

The work also produced an important leadership lesson. Involving frontline employees was not enough. Existing project leaders needed to participate earlier so they could help shape the solution rather than experience the work as a judgment on their prior decisions. Transformation affects ownership, authority, professional identity and internal influence, and those dynamics have to be managed alongside process and technology decisions.

AI is the newest major transformation wave, following the internet, big data and broad digitalization. The technology is different, but many of the organizational risks are familiar. That is why I undertook this research.



Four transformation waves. The technology changes each time; the organizational risks largely repeat.



RESEARCH QUESTION AND HYPOTHESES

What separates data, digital transformation and AI investments that create measurable commercial value from those that do not? The research examined whether five operating conditions: organizational readiness, dedicated ownership, executive sponsorship, incentive alignment and a defined method for measuring value, were present, and whether their presence was associated with fuller delivery of expected outcomes.



READINESS, THEN STRATEGY, THEN DEPLOYMENT

Readiness means diagnosing where today's norms, power, and incentives will resist tomorrow's strategy, and adjusting them before capital is committed. It is not a checklist run at kickoff. Alongside the conditions the survey measured, four structural requirements need to be in place before launch rather than after it:

01**An Aligned Senior Team**

If key leaders are not genuinely on board, resolve that friction before launch. It does not dissolve on contact with a roadmap.

02**Defined Leadership**

A clearly named leader, with the emotional intelligence to map where the cultural resistance sits and the standing to influence through inclusion rather than mandate.

03**Explicit Resources and Architecture**

Protected capital, protected talent, and a structure insulated from business as usual, which will otherwise reclaim both.

04**Sustained Support**

Commitment has to outlast a single budget cycle; short-cycle support is how initiatives stall before they can deliver.



METHODOLOGY AND LIMITATIONS

This research used a voluntary convenience sample drawn from one senior-executive education cohort. The full AMP 210 cohort at Harvard Business School, approximately 148 participants though cohort membership changed during the program, was invited by direct email between March 16 and April 7, 2026, with at least two reminder messages. Two follow-up executive interviews were conducted by video, each lasting approximately 30 to 60 minutes in a semi-structured format tailored to the participant's responses.



- The sample was not randomly selected and is not nationally or globally representative.
- Responses were self-reported and may reflect recall, perception and role-based bias.
- The survey was cross-sectional and cannot establish causality.
- Some subgroup analyses rely on small cell counts and are labeled exploratory.
- Many initiatives were still in progress, which limits final-outcome interpretation.
- The research did not validate a numerical risk score or universal success threshold.



RESPONDENT PROFILE

Respondents were senior leaders across general management, technology, finance and commercial functions within the AMP 210 cohort, surveyed in 2026. Individual companies, industries and locations are not identified, and no respondent is named or quoted by name anywhere in this report.

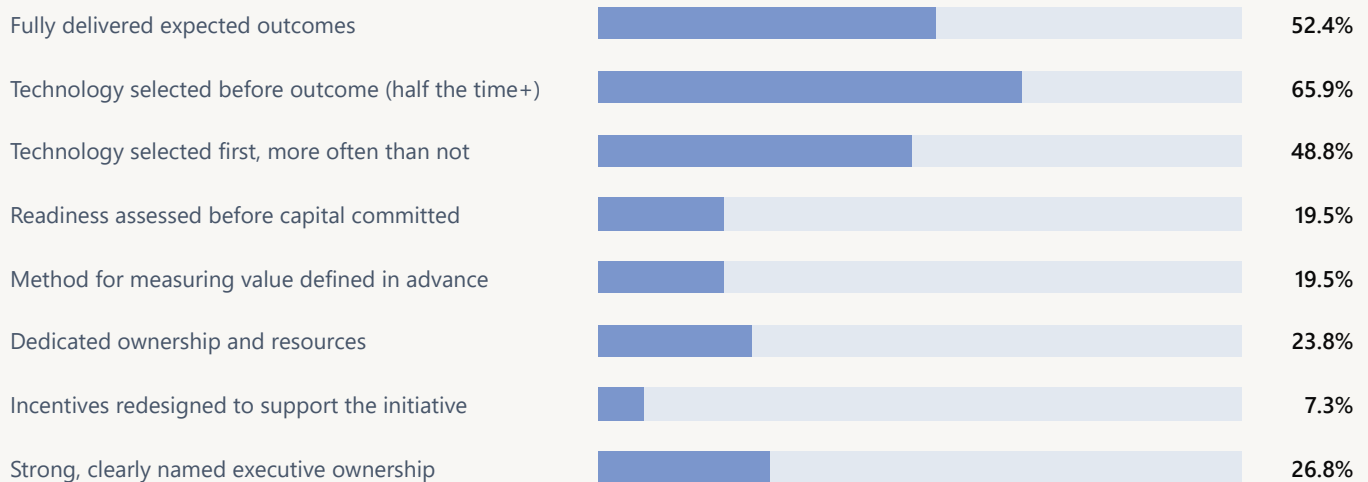


KEY FINDINGS

MEASURE	COUNT	PERCENT OR SCORE
Half or fewer initiatives fully delivered expected commercial outcomes	43 of 82	52.4%
Technology selected before business outcome at least half the time	54 of 82	65.9%
Technology selected first more often than not or almost always	40 of 82	48.8%
Organizational readiness assessed before capital committed	16 of 82	19.5%
Method for measuring value defined in advance	16 of 82	19.5%
Dedicated ownership and resources	19 of 80	23.8%
Incentives redesigned to support the initiative	6 of 82	7.3%
Strong, clearly named executive ownership	22 of 82	26.8%
Verified commercial-return score (1 to 10 scale)	82	Mean 5.2, median 5



ALL MEASURES AT A GLANCE





DETAILED RESULTS AND OBSERVED RELATIONSHIPS

9.2x

Full-delivery rate: dedicated ownership vs. business as usual

5.8x

Full-delivery rate: dedicated vs. shared ownership

2.5x

At-least-half delivery: incentives redesigned vs. no change

COMPARISON	OBSERVED RESULT	STATISTICAL NOTE
Dedicated ownership vs business as usual	26.3% vs 2.9% full delivery, 9.2x	Fisher exact $p=.0168$ (5 of 19 vs 1 of 35). Strong observed association; small groups; not causal proof.
Dedicated vs shared ownership	26.3% vs 4.5%, 5.8x	Fisher exact $p=.0795$ (5 of 19 vs 1 of 22). Directional; not conventionally significant.
Incentives redesigned vs no change	50% vs 20% reporting at least half delivered, 2.5x	Fisher exact $p=.1506$; redesigned group $n=6$. Exploratory only.
Zero key conditions vs at least one	0 of 32 vs 7 of 50 fully delivered	Fisher exact $p=.0391$. Observed sample difference; avoid universal claims.
Number of conditions present vs verified-return score	Spearman $\rho=.424$	$p<.001$. Moderate positive association; not causal proof.

All statistical comparisons are two-sided Fisher exact tests or a Spearman rank correlation, run against the final 82-response dataset. These describe observed associations within this sample and should not be read as proof of causation.



ANONYMOUS INTERVIEW THEMES

“The initiative described as successful had a clearer connection to the business objective, stronger accountability, and more disciplined attention to adoption and measurable outcomes.

The initiative that underperformed reflected a gap between the intended strategy and the operating conditions required to execute it: a business case had been approved, but ownership, resourcing and the definition of value stayed unresolved after launch.



COMPARISON WITH EXTERNAL RESEARCH

Together, these studies reinforce the need to distinguish experimentation, adoption and isolated use-case performance from verified enterprise value. My survey adds a practitioner-level observation to that pattern: 65.9% of respondents said their organizations selected the technology before the commercial outcome had been defined, which is the point at which the rest becomes hard.

**80%+**

MCKINSEY, 2025

Of respondents saw no tangible enterprise-level EBIT impact from generative AI.

**More than
two-thirds**

DELOITTE, 2025

Expected 30% or fewer of experiments to be fully scaled within three to six months.

**56%**

PWC, 2026

Of CEOs reported neither higher revenue nor lower costs from AI in the prior year.

The failure is rarely dramatic. Resources get quietly withdrawn to cover business as usual. Two initiatives draw on the same finite talent pool with no stated first priority. The people who stand to lose control, budget, or status do not object in the meeting; they simply do not move. None of that shows up on a milestone dashboard until the return is already gone.

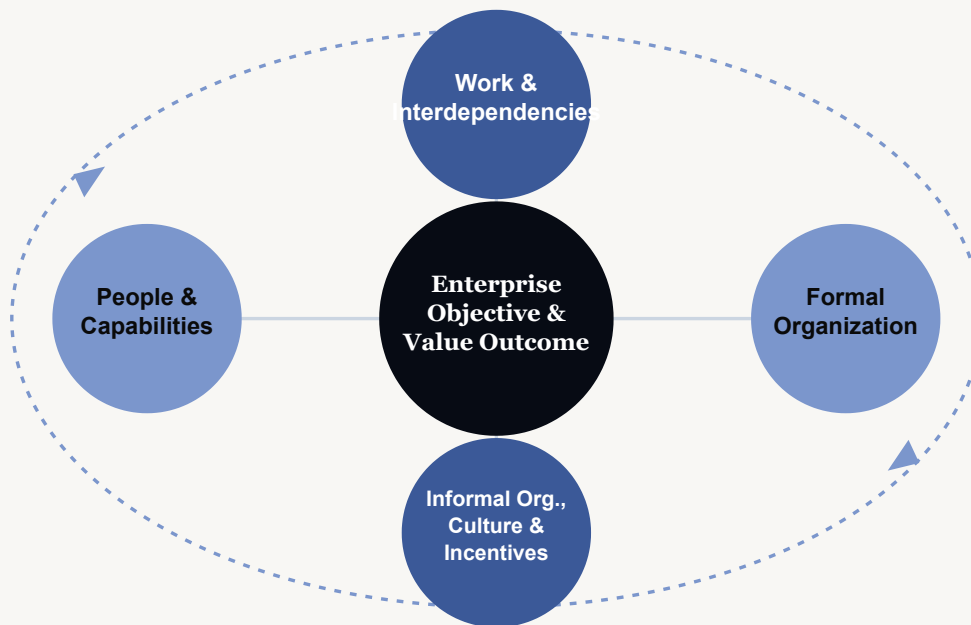
CENTRAL FINDING

One missing condition does not guarantee failure, but every unresolved condition increases execution risk.



FROM RESEARCH FINDING TO ORGANIZATIONAL DIAGNOSIS

The research identifies conditions associated with stronger delivery. The Congruence Model, developed by David A. Nadler and Michael L. Tushman, provides a practical way to investigate those conditions before additional capital is committed. It is not a survey-derived scoring method. It is a structured way to determine whether the organization is configured to deliver the intended business outcome.



Work and Interdependencies

Workflows, customer journeys, handoffs, data, systems, dependencies and required decisions.

People and Capabilities

Skills, dedicated capacity, accountable leadership and frontline knowledge.

Formal Organization

Ownership, decision rights, governance, funding and operating model.

Informal Organization, Culture and Incentives

Leadership behavior, informal power structures, cultural norms and incentives.

Technology investment is more likely to create value when the work, people, formal organization and informal organization are aligned with the objective being funded.

The checklist and diagnostic guidance translate the research findings into practical executive questions. They are not a validated numerical scoring model.

Nadler, David A., and Michael L. Tushman. "A Model for Diagnosing Organizational Behavior." *Organizational Dynamics*, 1980.



TECHNOLOGY INVESTMENT RISK CHECKLIST

One missing condition does not guarantee failure, but every unresolved condition increases execution risk. Twelve conditions to check before or during a major investment:



The business outcome was not clearly defined before the technology was selected.



The initiative lacks visible sponsorship from a senior leader with sufficient authority.



Leadership is not aligned that the initiative is an enterprise priority.



No executive is financially accountable for the value outcome.



The operating model, decision rights or ownership are ambiguous.



Employees are expected to deliver the transformation in addition to unchanged full-time responsibilities.



The initiative lacks dedicated or protected resources.



Existing incentives continue to reward legacy priorities and behaviors.



Workflows, dependencies, frontline requirements or data flows have not been mapped adequately.



Required capabilities are missing or unavailable.



Governance tracks activity and delivery but not adoption and value.



Progress is inconsistent, costs are escalating or the expected return cannot be verified.



CEO AND BOARD TECHNOLOGY INVESTMENT REVIEW

Do not assign a numerical score or failure threshold. The study did not validate one. This tool is meant to prompt disciplined judgment rather than imply a diagnostic certainty the evidence does not support.



APPROVAL AND READINESS

- Business hypothesis and the commercial outcome being funded
- Accountable business owner and financial responsibility
- Dedicated team versus existing resources, and what is stopped or deferred if resources are shared
- Tasks, workflows, interdependencies, systems and data mapped
- Required capabilities and an accountable project leader
- Formal structure, decision rights and governance process
- Incentives and cultural signals aligned with the new priority
- Access and organizational authority to investigate and act



GOVERNANCE AND VALUE VERIFICATION

- Proof of value that will justify further investment
- Milestones for delivery, adoption and business value
- Metrics that measure delivery, adoption and business value separately
- How the business owner will demonstrate value and how Finance will verify it
- Assumptions most likely to be wrong
- Conditions that would trigger pause, redesign or stop
- What must be true before the initiative is scaled
- Who owns continuous optimization after implementation



DECISION GUIDE FOR UNDERPERFORMING INITIATIVES

A pattern of missed milestones, escalating costs or weak adoption, combined with unresolved conditions that were already identifiable, should trigger a pause and a structured diagnosis:





CONCLUSION AND CONTACT INVITATION

Commission an independent diagnostic before approving more capital. If your organization is investing in data, digital transformation, technology or AI and is not seeing the expected progress or financial return, I can help determine what is preventing the initiative from creating value, right-size the investment and operating model, and lead the work through implementation and verified results.



GET IN TOUCH

Email zacharyleifer@gmail.com or visit zacharyleifer.com.



REFERENCES AND SUGGESTED CITATION

Leifer, Zachary. *Architecting More Predictable Enterprise Value from Data, Technology and AI Investment*. State of Mind Strategies, 2026.

McKinsey and Company, *The state of AI: How organizations are rewiring to capture value*, March 12, 2025.

Deloitte, *The Path to Sustainable Generative AI Value Balances Passion, Pragmatism and Patience*, January 21, 2025.

PwC, *29th Global CEO Survey: Leading through uncertainty in the age of AI*, 2026.



ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Zachary Leifer is a Las Vegas-based commercial growth and transformation executive who has served as Chief Marketing Officer at 1/ST Technology, Chief Commercial Officer at PokerAtlas and Vice President of Corporate Information Technology at Las Vegas Sands, giving him experience on both sides of transformation. Through State of Mind Strategies, he advises leadership teams on commercial growth, customer data, transformation, technology strategy and AI value creation.



Harvard Business School

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Cornell University

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